they should begin interception: one ship had been spotted 1,800 miles from Cuba. The president clearly had doubts whether it constituted a legitimate target, but his brother had none: “I don’t think that’s too far. If it keeps coming…” McNamara was opposed to interception at such a distance and played for time: “I recommend that we not, tonight, decide the issue on that particular ship that’s 1,800 miles out.” He suggested following the ships’ movements for the time being. Robert Kennedy was clearly disappointed. “As I say, I don’t see any problem,” he began, before continuing: “I think it would be damn helpful to come in with that kind of evidence.”[6]

Dean Rusk joined the debate on the side of the president. “If they seem to turn around, give them the chance to turn around and get on their way,” he told the gathering. Robert Kennedy jumped back into the discussion, pushing his argument on how to deal with the “hullabaloo” that could be created by the intercept: seizing weapons and taking pictures of them would make Soviet complaints groundless. “Well, I think I can see that, Bob,” responded the clearly worried Rusk. “The problem here is that, from the Soviet point of view, they’re going to be as sensitive as a boil.” He reminded Robert and others of the purpose of the blockade as he saw it: to keep the Soviets out of Cuba. John Kennedy entered the discussion as a peacemaker. He proposed to postpone the decision until the next day.

The president’s proposal was accepted. For the moment, Rusk probably wanted nothing more. The delay allowed him to give diplomacy a chance. With Llewellyn Thompson, he produced a draft letter from Kennedy to Khrushchev urging Soviet ships to stay away from the quarantine line. “The idea was,” said Thompson, explaining the purpose of the letter: “they [Khrushchev and the Soviet leadership] will tonight all be deciding on what instructions are going to the ships.” The draft letter read: “I hope that you will issue immediately the necessary instructions to your ships to observe the terms of the quarantine.… We have no desire to seize or fire upon your vessels.” Kennedy agreed to send the letter but insisted on dropping the last sentence.[7]

What helped Rusk and his peace initiative was the president’s growing concern about the practical implementation of the blockade, especially the seizure of Soviet ships. “That’s what could happen,” said Kennedy, outlining possible difficulties following the announcement of a blockade.